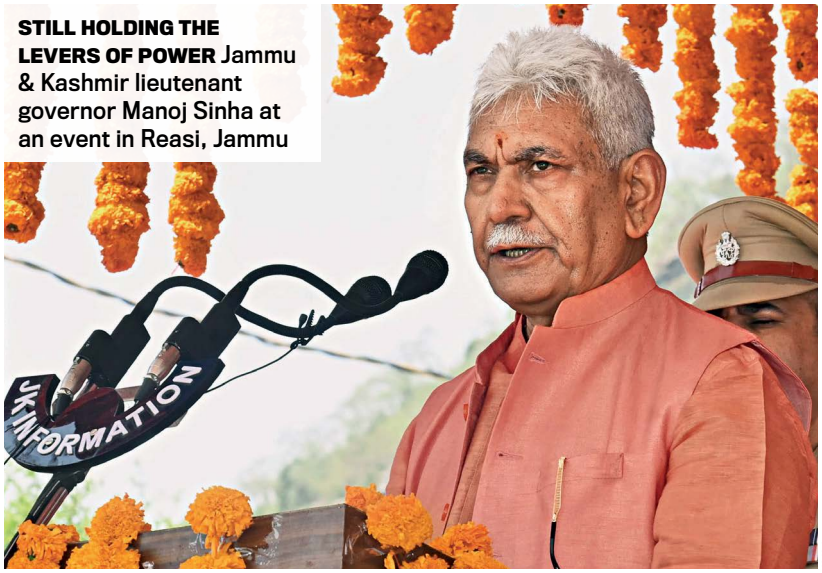


STILL HOLDING THE LEVERS OF POWER Jammu & Kashmir lieutenant governor Manoj Sinha at an event in Reasi, Jammu

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FOR OMAR, THE BIGGEST CHALLENGES ARE GETTING THE MODI GOVERNMENT TO RESTORE STATEHOOD TO J&K AND BRIDGING THE DIVIDE BETWEEN JAMMU AND THE VALLEY

vive its prospects in the plains of Jammu as well. It was partly their vociferous opposition to the BJP's policies and their consequences—including the truncating of the powers of states, the anti-encroachment drives in J&K to retrieve state land from 'people', high unemployment and surge in power bills—that propelled the JKNC to power. Omar's party is also being seen as the shield to combat the onslaught of New Delhi's policies post the Modi government's abrogation of Article 370. The BJP is being viewed with suspicion in the Valley for its alleged anti-Muslim initiatives across the country, with the recently introduced Waqf Amendment Bill drawing particularly strong resentment.

SETBACK FOR BJP

Meanwhile, the BJP can rightfully take credit for emerging as the party with the largest vote share—25.6 per cent compared to the JKNC's 23.4 per cent and the Congress's 12 per cent. It can also take heart from the 29 seats it won in Jammu despite the clear discontent in the region over civic and developmental issues. The Modi government deserves praise for ensuring the peaceful conduct of the election, which saw turnouts of over 65 per cent in most constituencies. In Jammu, the BJP had smartly dropped many of its stalwarts to make way for new faces. It also campaigned extensively on how the abrogation of Article 370 had brought peace to the region and that only the BJP could thwart the Valley's vociferous demand for its restoration. That argument overrode concerns over civic issues and saw the BJP win big in Jammu. Says a J&K expert, "The BJP certainly brought peace to the region and that was creditable. But what it didn't do was to bring sufficient development as they promised. Coupled with that was the aloofness of the administration. The BJP was also lucky that the Congress put up a poor show despite the people seething in fury against the administration and so they were able to cash in on the peace dividend."

But the results are a setback both for the BJP and the Modi government. After all, they had controlled all the levers of power in J&K for the past five years. Through the delimitation process, they were able to increase the number of seats in Jammu by six—from 37 to 43—while giving Kashmir only one additional seat, taking the number up to 47 from 46. The delimitation process also saw nine constituencies being carved out in Jammu and reserved for scheduled tribes. Simultaneously, the BJP tried to win over the Pahari community by including them in the reserved category. But despite the party's efforts to woo Muslim tribal voters, it failed to make any impact, with the JKNC-Congress alliance bagging seven seats. The two other seats reserved for STs were won by independents. The BJP's alleged strategy of shoring up the numbers by unleashing rumoured proxies, such as the J&K Apni Party and the Democratic Progressive Azad Party (DPAP), apart from a host of Independents, to cut into JKNC's vote also failed.

Another blowback from this election is the decimation of the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) headed by former chief minister Mehbooba Mufti. In the 90-seat assembly, the PDP was reduced to three, winning only Kupwara, Pulwama and Tral. The NC swept South Kashmir, which was considered to be a PDP stronghold of the PDP, winning all the four seats in Anantnag district. Among these was the Mufti family bastion Srigufwara-Bijbehara constituency, from where Iltija Mufti, Mehbooba's daughter, unsuccessfully made her electoral debut. Young and articulate, the 37-year-old lost to JKNC leader Bashir Ahmad Veeri, ending the three-decade-long political domination of the Mufti family since 1996 in this seat. Iltija, though, vows to continue her fight. However, all political players will now have to navigate the minefield that is J&K and rise above petty political considerations to ensure that both peace and development prevail in this sensitive border region. ■